Q+A

STORIES FIND ME

Oscar-winning producer ***Guneet Monga Kapoor*** *celebrates the National Award win for her film* Kathal



Q. Where were you when you got news of the National Award?

I was in a narration with Tahira Kashyap Khurrana and, initially, I couldn't believe it. It took a long time for it to sink in that *Kathal* won Best Hindi Feature. It's a huge honour. Very often, it feels like that in our fast-paced world, there is no space for storytelling that takes its time to unfold. *Kathal* is all about *thehraav* [pause].

Q. Have your reasons for backing a film evolved over the years?

What hasn't changed is my child-like fascination for how movies are made. I believe that stories find me instead of me going out to look for them. At our production house Sikhya, we are in service to a story and it's our responsibility to present it in its best form.

Q. What do you remember about Yashowardhan Mishra pitching this film to you?

I love the way Yashowardhan works. *Kathal* wasn't written in an airconditioned home in Mumbai—and it shows. He belongs to a village in Chhattisgarh and spent months doing research on the ground. When he narrated it to me, it was almost like a stand-up routine.

Q. You launched the India chapter of the Women in Film fellowship this year. Why is this important for you?

The stats are stark—less than 3 per cent of our directors are women; overall, they make up less than 10 per cent across all areas of filmmaking, be it writing, editing or cinematography. We need to create opportunities for women, so things can change.

—with Karishma Upadhyay

Photograph by BANDEEP SINGH